On October 10, Prime Minister Narendra Modi sounded a warning bell in his home state Gujarat, cautioning BJP workers about a "silent" campaign by the rival Congress in the villages. "You need to remain alert in the coming elections. They [the Congress] have adopted a new strategy...they do not speak, but are reaching out in villages, holding meetings," a wary Modi said in Ahmedabad. A few days later, in a meeting with BJP leaders in Delhi, Union home minister Amit Shah talked about the urgent need to counter the electoral challenge from the Aam Aadmi Party, led by Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal. He felt the party could soon occupy the main Opposition space not just in Gujarat but in other states as well. The two red flags raised by the Modi-Shah duo indicate the challenges the saffron party faces in the assembly polls in Gujarat, a state it has ruled uninterruptedly for nearly 25 years. BJP sources say the ambition this time is to beat the 149-seat record (out of a total 182) the Congress set in 1985, but then reality plays spoiler—the anti-incumbency of over two decades,



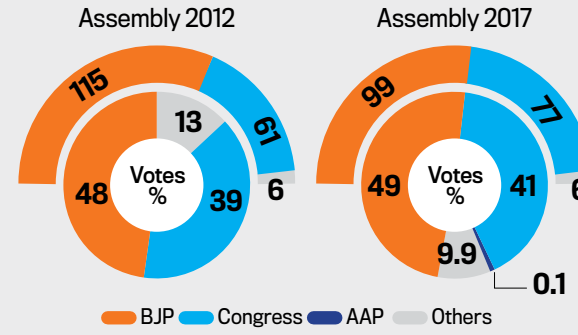
GETTY IMAGES

PAST RECORD

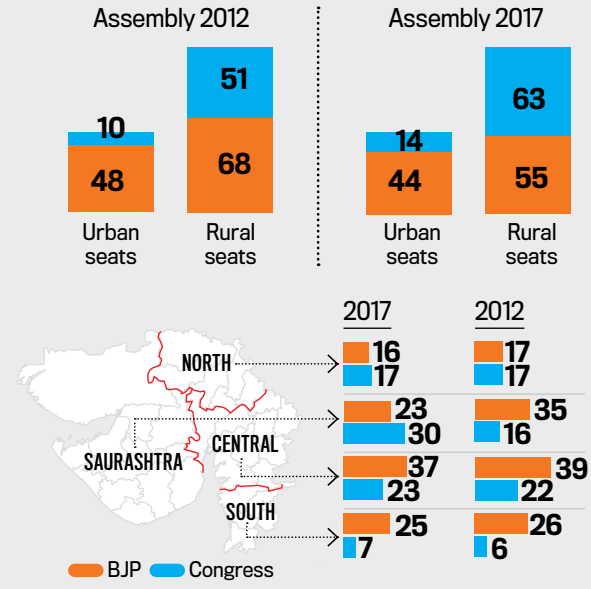
The previous two Gujarat assembly polls saw BJP wins, but 2017 also had a few close calls

Partywise break-up

Total seats: 182

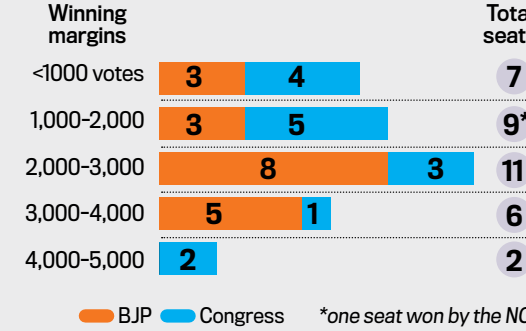


Regionwise break-up



The Cliffhangers

Slim victory margins in 35 seats in 2017 indicate that a third player may swing the results in any direction



Graphic by ASIT ROY